

PEACE MAKERS – RWANDA FINAL ACTIVITIES REPORT



Photo 1: Peacemakers students from Groupe Scolaire Karama – Kigali City.

February – March 2023.

INTRODUCTION

AKWOS is Non-Governmental Organization created in 1998 with legal personality no 64/11 of 20/04/2009. The mission of AKWOS is to Empower East-African Women through sports starting from Rwanda, in Education, gender equality, peace-building, conflict management and decision making. By doing so, we long to see a Rwandan Society free of Gender Discrimination and which respects Women's Full Participation and Inclusion in Leadership, Peace building and Decision making.

BASIC INFORMATION

After 1994 Genocide against Tutsi the country was torn apart, infrastructures were destroyed with many victims including women who were raped, infected with HIV/AIDS and orphans became homeless. Among many consequences of the Genocide: Rwandan community was left with no hopes, survivors and perpetrators lost trust among each other. In response to the above-mentioned consequences, Mrs. Felicite RWEMARIKA, founded the Organization of Women in Sports (AKWOS) to contribute to the reconstruction, reconciliation and rebuilding the society with a strategic approach of using sports in promoting gender, building peace and reconciliation among Rwandan community.

AKWOS Vision:

A society free of gender discrimination and which respects women's rights.

AKWOS Mission:

To effectively empower women starting from Rwanda, through sports and education, as well as contribute to their social-economic empowerment hence improving their wellbeing and self-esteem

AKWOS Core Values

AKWOS organizational culture is built on the following values:

a) Integrity:

Professionalism, moral uprightness, honesty, incorruptibility and trustworthiness will guide AKWOS' work and vision.

b) Accountability:

AKWOS willingly takes responsibility and ownership of its actions and results.

c) Confidentiality:

d) Equity: Promotion of inclusiveness and social justice for all will be the guiding principle in AKWOS' work and operations.

_e) Empathy: AKWOS thrives to extend the hand to the vulnerable in their context

ACTIVITY ONE: Meeting with School Coaches

- **Venue:** AKWOS Office
- **Date:** February 15th 2023
- **Duration:** 2 hours
- **Objective of the Meeting:** Resuming Peace and Sports Activities

The AKWOS staff team, coaches and volunteers met at the AKWOS Office to plan the activities to be implemented under the Peace and Sports Project. The meeting aimed at finding the right strategy to continue ensuring that pupils have not forgotten what they had learnt in the previous sessions regarding peace building and being involved in sports activities when still young.

During the meeting, the participants were reminded about the importance of this project, and the benefits of sports for a culture of peace building. Then, some concerns have been raised such as the need to purchase sport equipment for kids during the tournament, and the need to take into consideration every school schedule before deciding about the time of the sports activities.

The meeting was concluded after a long and productive discussion, and the way forward for the AKWOS team was to visit respective school directors to inform them of the upcoming resumption of activities.



Picture 1,2: Meeting with the Schools Trainers at AKWOS Office.

ACTIVITY TWO: Visiting Schools and Introduction of new AKWOS Volunteers

- **Venue:** GS Karama, GS Sainte Famille, GS Kimisagara and Ape Rugunga

- **Date:** February 17th 2023
- **Duration:** Half day
- **Objective of the Visiting Schools:** Introducing new Volunteers that are going to be working with kids in practices.

The AKWOS Team composed of two volunteers and project coordinator went to the schools (GS Karama, GS Kimisagara and Ape Rugunga) with the purpose of introducing the new volunteers to the beneficiaries, as both parties will work closely together during this new practice period. Fortunately, the visits were successful, and all the schools agreed to collaborate with AKWOS under this project once again. Afterward, respective schedules have been released for each school based on their availability.



Photo 3, 4, 5, 6: Visit of AKWOS team to beneficiary schools.

ACTIVITY THREE: SCHOOLS TOURNAMENT

- **Date:** February 22nd 2023
- **Venues:** GS Sainte Famille and Ape Rugunga
- **Duration:** 1 An Hour
- **Objective of the Tournament:** Teaching the young children about the importance of living peacefully amongst themselves and spreading peace in their school and community through sport activities.

Prior to the start of the game, the importance of peacebuilding in education, as well as the opportunities that can arise when students themselves decide to take the lead in these initiatives have been highlighted to the kids. The tournament served as a platform for AKWOS to explain to students how peacebuilding can assist the future generation better comprehend and address problems that threaten the rule of law, thereby equipping them to take the lead in constructing a more equal, peaceful, secure, and stable society. At the end of the event, the kids were capable of knowing how establishing peace contributes to human development, fosters human togetherness and solidarity, and helps protect lives and property.

Result of the games:

- *Sainte famille pitch:* Sainte Famille **3** - GS Karama **1**
 - *Ape Rugunga pitch:* GS Kimisagara **2** - Ape Rugunga **0**
- Final game: Sainte Famille vs GS Kimisagara



Photos 7, 8: School teams tournament.

ACTIVITY FOUR: Final Match closing Schools Tournaments

- **Venue:** GS Sainte Famille
- **Date:** March 1st 2023
- **Duration:** 2 Hours
- **Objective of the Final Match:** Promoting a culture of peace among little children through sports.

Once again, prior to the start of the game, the objective of the project has been shared with the kids by highlighting the importance of peacebuilding through sport in education. Another goal of this project also is to cultivate the sports spirit within the kids, orienting their mindset to fight as a team, and not as an individual, as well as the behaviors to be adopted in case of failure. That goal has been transmitted during this final game. The team of GS Kimisagara won the tournament after a very long match.

During the post-game debriefing gathering all the players, and the coordinators of the project, kids were reminded to always keep the values they learned during this project with them, keep striving to build a culture of peace, and love sports to have a healthy life. ***“We are peacemakers”***.



Photos 9, 10: Final match at GS Sainte Famille pitch, and post-game debriefing.



Photo 11, 12: Awarding of the trophy to the school winner of the tournament

ACTIVITY FIVE: Raising White Cards

- **Venue:** GS Karama, GS Kimisagara, GS Sainte Famille and Ape Rugunga
- **Date:** March 20th-24th 2023
- **Duration:** 2 Hours
- **Objective of the Final Match:** Getting both kids; coaches raising #White Cards as a sign that sports can be used as a tool for peace and a concrete response to community issues.

As every year, AKWOS celebrates the International Day of Peace with different schools. For this year, the team went to GS Karama, GS Kimisagara, GS Sainte Famille and Ape Rugunga to prepare for the celebration of the big day.

The AKWOS team interviewed some of the students and coaches to ask them about the event, and what it means to them. Some of the responses were as follow:

“Can you please tell us briefly how you can relate Sport to Peace?”

- “Sports unites people and makes them live together in a peaceful way to achieve one goal as a team.”
- “Peace is the absence of war, where all people love each other and live in harmony without any discrimination. Peace is related to sports because you cannot do sports when there is no peace.”
- “According to me, peace means the absence of war, when people work in transparency with no any discrimination.”
- “Sports is related to the culture of peace because here we try to relate things like teaching kids how to live peacefully. As an example, we have what we call fair play where if someone offends another, this person comes back for an apology. This shows that players need to live peacefully.”
- “When we talk about peace, it means a place with no conflicts. You cannot separate sports from peace. You cannot play with someone whom you are not united with. When you play, you do it in a peaceful way, it happens to gain and fail when playing. When we are in a peace and sports session, there is no hatred, and when someone has done wrong to his friend like pushing him/her away, that person comes back to apologize saying” I am sorry dear, I had not planned to do so for you.” We call it fair play, and that is what should identify us in sports so that we live when none denies another, to be able to achieve one goal, all that, in a peaceful way.”

When the representant of AKWOS asked about the reason why they are raising their **#White card**, the answers were somehow all the same.

“Can you please tell me why you are raising your white card?”

- “I am raising my white card to show that sport can be used as a tool for peace and a concrete response to community/social issues.”

- "I am raising my white card to promote the culture of peace and its relationship with sports."
- "I am raising my white card to show that Peace is a more important thing that the world needs to progress."



Photo 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18: Peacemakers in every school raising #White Cards.

IMPACT	RECOMMENDATIONS	CHALLENGES
• Children in primary schools learnt about sports and their importance. They were taught that sports is a cure for non-communicable diseases and that doing it at a young age would improve their health. • Pupils learnt that peace is the basis of everything in building a better world. They were reminded that there is nothing they can do in the chaos, war, and conflict's presence. • They learnt they are the power of the future, and that they need peace. On top of that, they are responsible for making it happen all over the World.	• Request of more funds to fulfill parents request of expanding the project in many schools within the Country so that a big number of students can be part of it. Due to the results we have seen from this project, where young children learnt about sports and its importance, the culture of peace, we hope that this project will reach many children in different parts of the country so that peace is spread everywhere. • More time for coaches' training about "My Coach App" use. Trainers need more time for My Coach Application so that sports can be done in a technological way, and for children to get used to new teaching methods because now technology is at the forefront of everything and sports is not left behind.	• Very limited resources to get all needed materials and reach many schools in our community. The children revealed the obstacles they face for peace sports programs to go well, including the lack of necessary equipment such as appropriate shoes because there are some who play wearing sandals. • Playgrounds that are not in good condition and need to be repaired. It is very difficult to play, especially when the child falls down, it hurts a lot.

CONCLUSION

AKWOS is delighted to have achieved its objectives: to educate young people from elementary school in Kigali about sport and its importance, to educate them about the culture of peace so that they can build a better world without conflict, and to practice professional sports that will help them in the future as adults.

Prepared by: Triphine Murekatete
Peacemakers Project Coordinator

Approved by: Felicite Rwemarika
AKWOS Executive Director